

# She began a city-planning revolution

Jacobs thought small but smart

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Three women published books within a few months of one another in the early 1960s. They were "The Death and Life of Great American Cities" in 1961, by Jane Jacobs; "Silent Spring" in 1962, by Rachel Carson; and "The Feminine Mystique" in 1963, by Betty Friedan.

Each book changed the world. Each sparked a revolution that continues to this day.

Friedan's revolution was feminism, sometimes called, in its early days, "women's liberation." Carson's was environmentalism, the realization that human beings are brainlessly destroying the planet that supports our life. (Global warming is only the latest stage in a crisis Carson identified almost half a century ago.)

Jacobs, who died two weeks ago at 89, created a revolution in architecture and city planning. It was a revolution that permeated American life and thought so completely that it's almost been forgotten. Virtually everyone is a Jacobite today.

I was living in New York when I first read "Death and Life." New York was my first experience of a real city. I felt as if Jacobs were translating from a foreign language. She made legible the hidden social and economic mechanics of the mysterious city I was daily experiencing.

Years later, when we'd become friends, I asked Jane if she thought the burst of three great books by American women had anything to do with the repression of women in the period after World War II.

Those were the years when Rosie the Riveter and other career types were sent back to the suburban kitchen. Were these women energized by the need to push open a prison door?

It wasn't the kind of question Jacobs cared for — she rarely thought about herself — and she ignored it. But I think it's true, and I think all three books should be seen as interlocked — as, in a sense, facets of the same impulse: a feminine, humanitarian impulse, one based on experiencing the world as it is, rather than trying to shape it by big abstract theories like those of Le Corbusier and other moderns.

Jacobs wouldn't have said so, but she was an environmentalist too. The environment she cared about was the one we build for ourselves, not the one created by nature. She was a feminist as well, although she couldn't have cared less about feminist politics. I was lucky enough to witness her classic confrontation with James Rouse, the developer of the Quincy Market complex, in a debate at Faneuil Hall.



FRANK GUNN/ASSOCIATED PRESS/FILE 2000

Jane Jacobs wrote "The Death and Life of Great American Cities" and other books. She died two weeks ago at 89.

Even in appearance, they were opposites: Rouse a big man in golf-course lime-green slacks, Jacobs exaggeratedly modest in what appeared to be a home-sewn granny dress. Rouse spoke first, quoting famous words by Daniel Burnham, the great Chicago architect and planner: "Make no little plans; they have no magic to stir men's blood."

Jacobs brought down the house when she quietly announced, "I'm not sure big plans ever did have the magic to stir women's blood."

She believed in a world not of grand plans, of interstate highways and urban renewal projects, but rather in a world created by many small initiatives unfettered by government. Good cities were made by the neighbor and the corner grocer, multiplied by millions. Good planning should support the spontaneous, interactive life and growth of such initiatives. Master plans (note the masculine language), handed down from above, were usually stupid and brutal.

She was an activist as much as a writer. In Greenwich Village she joined a protest that killed a plan to push Fifth Avenue through Washington Square, then helped stop the egregious Lower Manhattan Expressway, which would have done to Manhattan what the Central Artery did to Boston.

Later, after she moved to Toronto so her sons could avoid the Vietnam draft, she was equally ac-

tive there, recently serving as a member of a new mayor's transition team. Together with planner Ken Greenberg, who's also active here in Boston, she recently persuaded Toronto to create a new zoning district in which all uses are permitted, none banned. Such a district could nurture the unplanned mix of residents, businesses, and other activities that she felt was the secret of any city's innovation and vitality.

The enduring fame of "Death and Life" annoyed Jacobs in her later years. She thought she'd written better books. Two favorites of my own: "Cities and the Wealth of Nations," which appeared in 1984, eerily predicts many aspects of the global economy of today. And "Systems of Survival" of 1992 is a brilliant discourse on the ways in which we organize society — although it's written in a fictional form for which the author had little talent.

With characteristic modesty, she also took the time to write a book hardly anyone read. "A Schoolteacher in Old Alaska" is about the life and adventures of her great-aunt, who taught on the islands off the Alaskan coast.

Jacobs was modest in other ways too. Once I was asked to sound her out about receiving the Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects, the highest American award for lifetime achievement. It had never been given to a woman or to a non-ar-

chitect (it still hasn't).

She knew perfectly well the prestige of the medal. Her husband was an architect. But my phone call was a comic disaster. Why, she wanted to know, was I interrupting her morning's work with something so trivial?

Jane once wrote that if we don't keep our eyes on reality, "we will be lost in fogs of our own making." She belongs in a small class of people who look at reality directly, not through the medium of ideas.

She reminds me, in that regard, of the Yale historian Vincent Scully or the British theorist Christopher Alexander. All three are people who spend zero time worrying about their place in the history of ideas. They simply go out into the world, see what they see, draw their conclusions, and publish them. Such people write as if they'd never read any books. They are invaluable.

I remember best a visit to Jane at her Toronto house a decade ago, when we spent a long Sunday afternoon on the front porch (the street was a solid row of front porches) eating ethnic pastries she'd bought somewhere. She was already overweight then, but she moved quickly as she climbed up and down stairs to show me the house.

On each level there were modest gardens on decks and porches. In her workplace was the small, old-fashioned, manual portable typewriter on which she did her writing. A son, who lived nearby, dropped over to see how she was doing. It was the life of an urban villager at its best.

All revolutions breed excess, and Jacobs's is no exception. When it comes to city planning today, central governments in the US are too weak and private citizens are too powerful. We're now governed by the small minority of neighborhood activists who are willing to drink stale coffee out of styrofoam cups at 11 p.m. at a civic meeting. Often they do a better job than the master planners of old, but often they don't.

We still need big plans. We need experts and professionals. How about a national high-speed railroad system? How about metropolitan growth boundaries, to stop the insidious spread of sprawl? How about a TVA-type planning agency to deal with the problems of the hurricane coasts, from Cape Cod to Texas? It's important not to let the balance slip too far in the direction of amateur planning.

Last December, I got a holiday card from Jane. You could tell, from what she wrote, that she was failing a little. Together with a Toronto friend, I planned a dinner with her to take place this spring. We didn't make it soon enough.

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